The newest partner working with the junta is India. Initially India had been a critic of the regime and its brutal human rights policy. For example, the government had awarded the Nehru Prize to Aung San Suu Kyi in 1995. As India emerged as a potential regional power, the government's priorities began to change. India's main concerns turned toward weapons sales, and exploitation of Myanmar's abundant natural resources. It became essential for India's geostrategic position to counter the growing Chinese influence over the junta. This change has allowed the Myanmar authorities to play India off against China.

Unquestionably, it has been the Chinese government that is most responsible for the continued intransigence of the military regime in Myanmar. Border trade between China and Myanmar has always been lucrative. As the insurgency issue quieted down, border profits soared. As Chinese regional influence increased in the post–Cold War period, Myanmar's relations with neighboring countries improved dramatically. Chinese trade in natural resources such as timber and gems increased in the 1990s. Chinese products entered the Myanmar markets, usually at the expense of Thai commodities.

Ethnic Han Chinese pushed into Myanmar with the hopes of reaping the economic benefits from the new open-door policy. Several urban areas saw a marked increase in the Chinese population. The net results unfortunately did not benefit the vast majority of Myanmar citizens. The junta's leadership derived the gains. Furthermore, the Buddhist influence was altered by the arrival of the Chinese. Offerings to the monks were reduced, leading to the decline of Buddhist influence in numerous urban centers. Furthermore, the dark side of globalization was apparent as cities became saturated with bars and a vibrant sex industry was flourishing.

The most significant area of Chinese influence was in national defense and military procurement. The junta's main weapons supplier was China. Everything from missiles, tanks, jet fighters, and trucks were purchased from China. Furthermore, Chinese leverage against insurgent groups was significant. This took pressure off of the regime and allowed them to concentrate on selective military targets. Finally, the Chinese were responsible for upgrading Myanmar's military infrastructure.